

Committee: Historical Security Council

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Topic: The Congo Crisis

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Introduction

Despite gaining independence from Belgium only two months earlier, the Republic of the Congo is already facing severe political and military instability. The mutiny of the Force Publique, Belgian military intervention, and the secession of the mineral-rich province of Katanga have already challenged the authority and territorial integrity of the Congolese government. Although the United Nations Operation in the Congo (ONUC) was established to assist in restoring order and protecting Congolese sovereignty, the involvement of foreign powers, as well as disagreements about the mission's responsibilities have made the crisis increasingly difficult to control.

With President Joseph Kasavubu and Prime Minister Patrice Lumumba now dismissing one another from office and claiming conflicting authority, the Congo faces a political crisis alongside its ongoing military instability. As Lumumba receives assistance from the Soviet Union and Western states fear the spread of communism into Central Africa, it is essential to address the Crisis in Congo before the country's political instability develops into a much larger international conflict.

Key Words

Katanga Secession — The declaration of independence by the province of Katanga under Moïse Tshombé on 11 July 1960, challenging the territorial integrity of the newly independent Congo.

Sovereignty — The authority of a state to govern its own territory and political affairs without external interference, a central issue in the Congo Crisis.

Secession - The act of separating a territory from an existing state in order to form an independent state or government.

Constitutional crisis / paralysis - A situation in which the legal authority of government institutions or leaders is unclear or disputed.

Territorial integrity - The principle that a state's territory and borders should not be divided or altered through outside interference.

Katanga - A mineral-rich province in the south of the Congo that declared independence under leader Moïse Tshombe in July 1960.

Loi Fondamentale (Fundamental Law) — Provisional constitutional framework of the Republic of the Congo at independence, defining the powers of the President, Prime Minister, Parliament, and institutions of the state.

Cold War — The political, military, and ideological rivalry between the United States and Soviet Union that shaped foreign involvement in the Congo.

General Overview

The Congo gained independence from Belgium on 30 June 1960, with Joseph Kasa-Vubu serving as President and Patrice Lumumba as Prime Minister. However, the country had not been given enough time to develop a trained Congolese administration or officer corps. The army remained mainly controlled by Belgian officers, while most senior positions in government and business were still occupied by Europeans. This created major tensions between Congolese soldiers and their commanders, leading to a mutiny shortly after independence.

Belgium responded to the unrest by sending troops into the Congo, claiming that it was protecting Belgian citizens and restoring order. The Congolese Government viewed this intervention as a violation of its sovereignty and requested military assistance from the United Nations. In response, the Security Council adopted Resolution 143 on 14 July, calling for Belgian withdrawal and authorizing the Secretary-General to provide military assistance to the Congo. The UNOC was created soon afterwards.

The crisis worsened when Moïse Tshombe declared the independence of Katanga on 11 July. Katanga was one of the wealthiest parts of the Congo because of its copper, cobalt, uranium, and other mineral resource abundance. The Central Government considered the secession illegal and accused Belgium of supporting Katanga in order to maintain access to the Congo's economic resources. Tshombe, however, argued that Katanga had the right to govern itself and resisted PM Lumumba's authority.

The UN attempted to maintain neutrality. ONUC was expected to help restore order and protect the Congo's territorial integrity, but it was not intended to fight on behalf of one political faction. This created tension with Lumumba, who wanted United Nations forces to assist the Central Government in ending the Katanga secession. When ONUC refused to provide direct military support for this objective, Lumumba requested assistance from the Soviet Union. Soviet aircraft and logistical support were subsequently provided to the Congolese Government, causing the United States and other Western states to fear that the Congo could become a Soviet ally.

On 5 September 1960, President Kasa-Vubu dismissed Lumumba as Prime Minister and appointed Joseph Ileo to form a new government. Lumumba rejected the dismissal and claimed that Kasa-Vubu no longer had the authority to remain President. Both men appealed to Parliament and attempted to maintain control over the government, army, communications, and diplomatic representation of the Congo. As a result, the Congo is now facing a two-headed government, while the United Nations must decide how to preserve peace without determining the country's political leadership.

Major Parties Involved

- Joseph Kasa-Vubu – The President of the Congo. Kasa-Vubu argues that Lumumba's policies have created instability and increased the threat of Soviet influence. He supports Lumumba's dismissal and the appointment of Joseph Ileo as Prime Minister.
- Patrice Lumumba – The Prime Minister of the Congo and a strong supporter of national unity. Lumumba opposes Katanga's secession and argues that the Central Government has the right to receive assistance from other countries. His cooperation with the Soviet Union has caused concern among Western states.
- Moïse Tshombe and Katanga – Tshombe leads the secessionist government of Katanga. Katanga opposes Lumumba's Central Government and resists the deployment of ONUC into the province. Its economic importance has made the secession especially significant for both Belgium and the Congo.
- Belgium – Belgium has sent troops into the Congo and remains connected to Katanga through military personnel, advisers, and economic interests. Belgium claims that its

intervention is necessary to protect its citizens, while the Congolese Government and the Soviet Union accuse it of attempting to preserve colonial influence.

- United States and Western states – The United States and its allies support the unity of the Congo but are deeply concerned about Lumumba's relationship with the Soviet Union. They fear that Soviet involvement could turn the Congo into a communist foothold in Africa.
- Soviet Union – The Soviet Union supports Lumumba and condemns Belgian intervention and Western influence in Katanga. It argues that ONUC has failed to protect Congolese sovereignty and has prevented the legitimate Central Government from restoring control over its own territory.
- African and Asian states – Newly independent African and Asian states are concerned that the Congo Crisis could establish a precedent for former colonial powers to interfere in independent countries. Many support Congolese territorial integrity and the withdrawal of Belgian forces, although they also want to prevent the Congo from becoming a battleground between the United States and the Soviet Union.
- United Nations and ONUC – The United Nations is responsible for assisting the Congo, supporting the withdrawal of foreign troops, protecting civilians, and maintaining peace. However, ONUC is not supposed to choose between Kasa-Vubu and Lumumba or impose a political solution on the Congolese people.

Timeline of Relevant Events

Year	Event
30 June 1960	The Congo gains independence from Belgium. Joseph Kasa-Vubu becomes President and Patrice Lumumba becomes Prime Minister.
5-6 July 1960	The Force Publique mutinies after independence, and violence spreads through areas within the country.
9 July 1960	Belgium begins sending troops into the Congo, with justification of claims that it is protecting Belgian citizens.
11 July 1960	Moïe Tshombe declares Katanga's independence.
12-13 July 1960	Kasa-Vubu and Lumumba request military assistance from the UN
14 July 1960	The UN SC adopts Resolution 143, calling for Belgian forces to be withdrawn, as well as authorizing assistance from the Congo.

22 July 1960	The SC adopts Resolution 145, reiterating the Congo's territorial integrity and political sovereignty.
Late July 1960	ONUC starts expanding operations across the Congo.
9 August 1960	The SC adopts Resolution 146, confirming that ONUC should enter Katanga while remaining neutral in the internal political dispute.
August 1960	Combat continues in Katanga and Kasai. Lumumba requests further assistance from the Soviet Union.
Late August 1960	Soviet aircraft and logistical support begin aiding the Congolese government.
5 September 1960	President Kasa-Vubu dismisses PM Lumumba and appoints Joseph Ileo to form a new government.
5 September 1960	Lumumba rejects the dismissal and declares that Kasa-Vubu has lost his authoritative power.

Relevant Documents

- UNSC Resolution 143, <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/112108?ln=en>
- UNSC Resolution 145, <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/112109?ln=en&v=pdf>
- UNSC Resolution 146, <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/112110?ln=en&v=pdf>
- Secretary-General's Reports on the Congo 1960, <https://www.un.org/depts/dhl/dag/time1960.htm>

Possible Solutions

Some possible solutions that delegates may want to consider are the following.

1. *A temporary constitutional mediation process*
 - The UN could create a neutral commission to examine the competing claims of Kasa-Vubu and Lumumba. This commission could consult the Congo's Parliament and act as an arbitrator by recommending a temporary arrangement without immediately recognizing either side as the sole legitimate government.
2. *A clearer ONUC mandate*
 - The SC could clarify that ONUC is responsible for protecting Congolese territorial integrity, supporting the withdrawal of foreign troops, and protecting civilians. At the same time, ONUC shouldn't be permitted to choose the Congo's government or fight on behalf of one political faction.

3. *The removal of foreign military influence*
 - The Council could request that Belgium, the Soviet Union, and other states cease in providing military personnel, weapons, aircraft, or advisers to Congolese factions. This could reduce the risk of the Congo becoming a direct conflict between the Cold War powers.
4. *Negotiations over Katanga*
 - The United Nations could facilitate negotiations between Tshombe and the Central Government concerning Katanga's political autonomy, mineral revenues, and relationship with Léopoldville. Katanga would not necessarily receive immediate independence, but its concerns could be addressed without accepting the permanent division of the Congo.

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- "Resolution 157 (1960)." *The United Nations Digital Library*, 1960,
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- “Resolution adopted by the Security Council at its 879th meeting on 22 July 1960 [calling upon Belgium to implement resolution 143 (1960) on the withdrawal of its troop].” *United Nations Digital Library*, 22 July 1960,.
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- “Mission Impossible: Hammarskjöld and the UN Mandate for the Congo (1960–1961).” *African Security*, vol. 10, no. 3/4, 2017, pp. 254–71. *JSTOR*,
www.jstor.org/stable/48598944.